Seamless experience and experiential value: driving flow in omnichannel retailing

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Abstract

Purpose – While a seamless experience is widely acknowledged as essential, its role in shaping deeper psychological states, especially the state of flow in the shopping journey, remains an ongoing area of research in marketing. Flow enables customers to immerse themselves in shopping with minimal effort; yet, it alone may not fully drive purchase intentions. Drawing on flow theory and experiential value theory, this study examines how experiential value, together with flow, shapes customer shopping intentions in an omnichannel retail context.

Design/methodology/approach – The data were collected from 351 omnichannel customers using a structured survey. The data analysis was done using PLS-SEM to test the proposed hypotheses.

Findings – The findings suggest that a seamless experience significantly contributes to the flow experience, which in turn influences shopping intentions across channels. Additionally, experiential value mediates the relationship between seamless experience and flow experience.

Practical implications – Omnichannel retailers can leverage the findings of this paper to shape customer-centric strategies that deliver seamless experiences and foster a state of flow. It also highlights the several dimensions of experiential value that customers derive during their omnichannel shopping journey, providing a basis for retailers to design strategies that align more closely with customers' evolving needs and expectations.

Originality/value – This study makes a contribution to the omnichannel retailing literature by integrating experiential value theory and flow theory to provide a more comprehensive understanding of the customer shopping intentions in omnichannel retail environments. It advocates the need to move beyond a seamless experience as a functional objective and emphasizes the role of experiential value as a critical factor that enhances flow and drives customer shopping intentions in omnichannel retailing.

Keywords Seamless experience, Experiential value, Omni-channel retail, Flow experience, Shopping intention

Paper type Research article

1. Introduction

In today's consumption environment, customers interact with retailers through multiple channels and touchpoints across their shopping journey, making omnichannel retailing a defining characteristic of contemporary retail ecosystems (Wu *et al.*, 2025; Silva *et al.*, 2024). Unlike traditional multichannel approaches, omnichannel retailing emphasizes the integration, consistency, and flexibility of customer touchpoints to ensure continuity throughout the shopping journey (Chang and Li, 2022). With the integration of the available shopping channels, omnichannel retailers aim to provide smooth and uninterrupted experiences that enable customers to transition effortlessly between channels during information search, product evaluation, and purchase decisions (Liu *et al.*, 2024).

The contemporary omnichannel retail environment is characterized by intense competition, driven by retailers' growing recognition that delivering a seamless customer experience is a strategic necessity. As customers increasingly expect smooth transitions and consistency across channels, retailers have responded by investing extensively in technology and service design to ensure seamless experiences (Sharma and Dutta, 2025). These investments are reflected in market projections, with the global omnichannel retailing market

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expected to grow from US$10.13 billion in 2025 to US$25.35 billion by 2032, representing a compound annual growth rate of approximately 14% (Coherent Marketing Insights, 2025).

With seamless experiences becoming increasingly common across omnichannel retailers, seamlessness serves as a basic expectation rather than a distinctive advantage, prompting businesses to seek new ways to differentiate themselves in an already competitive market (Wu *et al.*, 2025). Additionally, despite extensive efforts toward seamless omnichannel integration, customer shopping intentions continue to vary across channels, with many customers preferring specific channels to complete their purchases (Agrawal and Gupta, 2023). This raises a critical question: Is seamlessness alone the primary determinant of customer shopping intentions, or do other factors play a significant role (Liu and Liu, 2024)? Thus, highlighting the importance of looking beyond functional integration, this study aims to understand customers' omnichannel experiences at a deeper level.

Building on the importance of seamless omnichannel experiences, it is equally critical to understand how these experiences influence deeper psychological states that drive customer shopping intentions. While a seamless experience is widely acknowledged as essential, its role in shaping deeper psychological states, especially the state of flow, remains an ongoing area of research in marketing (Li and Gong, 2022). Previous studies also indicate that omnichannel integration can create conditions that lead to a flow experience (Liu *et al.*, 2024). Flow experience is an optimal experience in which a person is deeply absorbed, and everything else becomes irrelevant (Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). This allows customers to become fully immersed in shopping with minimal friction and cognitive effort. Hence, the current study aims to explore how this flow experience impacts customer shopping intentions in omnichannel retailing.

To address this research gap, this study focuses on a sector where omnichannel integration significantly influences how customers interact, explore, and make purchasing decisions. Moreover, data reveal that in the Indian retail market, the beauty and personal care sector is one of the most promising and emerging sectors to adopt omnichannel integration. This is highlighted by the rapid projected growth rate of the sector, which is to reach a global revenue of $646.20 billion in 2024. McKinsey and Company (2022), in its report "*Taking a Good Look at the Beauty Industry*", emphasizes the importance of delivering a seamless omnichannel experience to customers, particularly in this sector.

However, a key challenge in beauty and personal care retail is that online channels are primarily used for product exploration, often resulting in lower purchase conversion rates compared to in-store sales (De Canio and Fuentes-Blasco, 2021). This is observed particularly in the context of beauty and personal care retailing, where consumption is closely linked to sensory appeal, social influence, and customers' subjective perceptions. Thus, within this sector, retailers need to provide an experience that translates into the shopping intentions of potential customers across each shopping channel. So, we emphasize the need for retailers to understand the customers' omnichannel shopping experience in ways that encourage conversion across both online and offline touchpoints, particularly in this sector.

Although authors support the argument of seamless experience and flow experience to support the customer's intention to purchase. But, also believe that the state of flow in a retail journey may be strengthened, particularly in sectors like beauty and personal care, with an intervention. To strengthen and sustain flow experiences, it is critical to consider the value customers derive from their shopping experiences. Over time, the conceptualization of customer value has shifted from focussing solely on product-or service-based benefits to a broader emphasis on experiential value – the value customers derive from the overall consumption experience (Varshneya and Das, 2017). Thus, the current study examines the role of experiential value and flow experience as a critical bridge in driving customer shopping intentions within omnichannel environments.

To address the above-mentioned research objective, the study proposes the following research questions:

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RQ1. How does a seamless experience contribute to the generation of a flow experience in an omnichannel retail environment?

RQ2. How does the flow experience influence shopping intention in an omnichannel retail environment?

RQ3. How does the experiential value derived during an omnichannel shopping experience influence the relationship between seamless experience and flow experience?

2. Theoretical background and conceptual model

Taking theoretical support from "flow theory" (Csikszentmihalyi, 2000; Liu *et al.*, 2024) and "experiential value theory" (Mathwick *et al.*, 2001; Varshneya and Das, 2017), this study examines customers' shopping intentions in an omnichannel retail environment. These theories together provide a robust lens to examine not only the psychological immersion of customers during omnichannel shopping but also how this immersion is shaped and reinforced by the value they perceive from their interactions, particularly in the context of beauty and personal care retail. Flow theory (Csikszentmihalyi, 2000; Liu *et al.*, 2024) explains how seamless interactions across multiple channels can immerse customers in the shopping experience, creating a state of deep engagement and absorption. Complementing this, experiential value theory (Xu *et al.*, 2025; Varshneya and Das, 2017) elucidates how the values that customers derive from these immersive interactions – cognitive, hedonic, social, and ethical drive shopping intention.

Flow theory explains a psychological state in which individuals are fully absorbed in an activity, characterized by focused attention, enjoyment, and reduced awareness of time and surroundings (Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). In this state, individuals engage with minimal cognitive effort and high intrinsic motivation (Zhong and Hamouda, 2024). Flow experience (FE) has been widely studied across digital and retail contexts and has also gained attention in omnichannel retailing. In omnichannel contexts, seamlessness reflects the degree to which customers can transition across channels without disruption, inconsistency, or repetition of effort (Liu *et al.*, 2024). When channel interactions are consistent and uninterrupted, customers can remain focused on shopping-related activities rather than on managing channel boundaries, thereby increasing the likelihood of entering a flow-state (Li and Gong, 2022). Flow enhances the smooth transitions across channels that allow customers to remain engaged and absorbed in their shopping journey, strengthening flow experiences (Silva *et al.*, 2023). However, while flow captures the depth of immersion during shopping, it does not account for how customers evaluate their experiences or what motivates them to convert into purchase-related decisions (Fang and Chung, 2025).

Furthermore, experiential value theory has its roots in the concept of the experience economy. This theory emphasizes that customers assess retail encounters through the experiences generated during the shopping journey (Mathwick *et al.*, 2001). In omnichannel retailing, experiential value is formed cumulatively across multiple touchpoints as customers move between physical and digital channels (Ameen *et al.*, 2021; Xu *et al.*, 2025). Experiential value (EV) is central to customers, as they evaluate retailers not merely based on products or services, but on the multiple values derived during the shopping experience, such as convenience, enjoyment, social approval, and trust (Mpinganjira *et al.*, 2024). In this study, experiential value (EV) is conceptualized as a multidimensional construct comprising cognitive, hedonic, social, and ethical value (Varshneya and Das, 2017). Cognitive value reflects perceived service efficiency across omnichannel touchpoints, including time savings, convenience, and ease of effort. Hedonic value captures emotional gratification, such as enjoyment and excitement, during the shopping journey. Social value relates to perceived social recognition and approval, while

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ethical value encompasses trust, privacy, and perceptions of responsible and transparent retailer practices across channels.

Understanding the importance of EV in the omnichannel shopping journey, the authors advocate that EV also serves as a critical mechanism linking SE and FE. While seamless interactions facilitate flow by enabling uninterrupted engagement across channels, EV captures what customers derive from being immersed in the shopping journey. Accordingly, EV is positioned in this study as a key mediator that strengthens the relationship between SE and FE in omnichannel retailing. The proposed conceptual model of the study is described in Figure 1.

3. Hypothesis development

Drawing on flow theory and experiential value theory, this study examines how experiential value, together with flow, shapes customer shopping intentions in an omnichannel retail context. The proposed conceptual model (Figure 1) first explains how the consistent efforts of omnichannel retailers to deliver a seamless experience (SE) facilitate the emergence of flow experience (FE). Second, it integrates this retailer-driven SE with the experiential value (EV) derived by customers during their omnichannel shopping journey. This

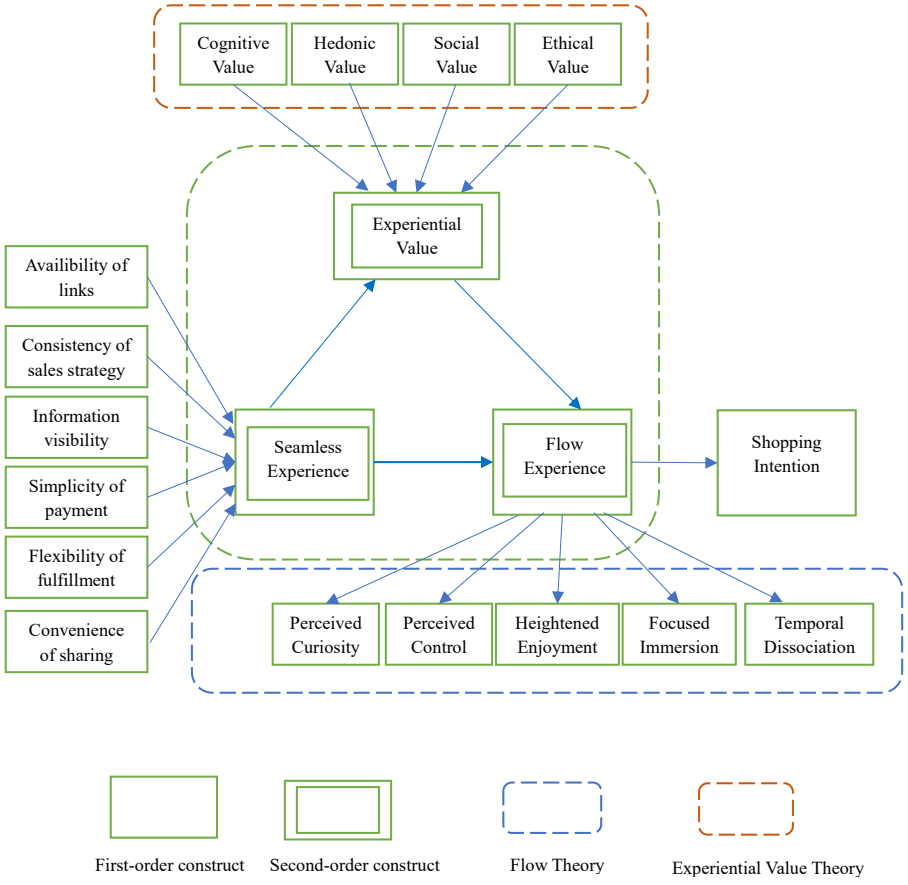


Figure 1. Proposed conceptual model. Source: Authors' own work

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approach thus presents an integrated view of retailer and customer centricity in the omnichannel shopping journey.

Adopting the conceptualization of Chang and Li (2022), this study conceptualizes SE as a second-order formative construct with six reflective dimensions: availability of links (smooth transitions across channels), consistency in sales strategies (alignment of pricing and promotions across channels), information visibility (accessibility of product information across channels), simplicity of payment (secure and streamlined transactions across channels), flexibility of fulfilment (allowing customers to choose from multiple, adaptable delivery or pickup options), and convenience of sharing (ease of sharing product information and shopping experiences across channels and digital platforms).

Building on the work of Liu *et al.* (2024), this study conceptualizes FE as a "second-order reflective construct" with five reflective first-order dimensions: first, "perceived curiosity" that refers to heightened sensory and cognitive arousal; second, "perceived control" that denotes the individual's sense of command over the activity; third, "heightened enjoyment" reflects the intrinsic pleasure derived from the experience; fourth, "focused immersion" that involves deep concentration where competing attentional demands are blocked out; and fifth, "temporal dissociation" that signifies a distorted perception of time when involved in an activity. This paper adopts these dimensions to assess the FE in the omnichannel retailing context.

This research also emphasizes that the customers' shopping intentions are shaped by the EV that customers derive across various touchpoints during their omnichannel shopping journey (Alexander and Varley, 2025). Drawing on the concept of "experience economy", the study advocates that EV is a critical driver of customer shopping intentions in omnichannel retailing. This study proposes that to ensure a more sustained and engaging shopping journey, it becomes imperative that customers also derive an EV during their omnichannel shopping journey. The conceptual model thus proposes that EV mediates SE and FE generated in an omnichannel retail environment, thereby influencing customers' shopping intentions (see Figure 1).

To conceptualize EV, this study adopts Varshneya and Das (2017), defining it as a second-order formative construct with four reflective dimensions. Cognitive value reflects service efficiency, including time savings, convenience, and ease of effort. Hedonic value captures emotional gratification, such as enjoyment and excitement, during the shopping journey. Social value relates to social recognition and approval, while ethical value includes trust, privacy, and perceptions of responsible retailer behaviour.

3.1 Seamless experience and flow experience in omnichannel retailing

Over the past decade, marketing literature has highlighted a shift from traditional multichannel retailing, where offline and online channels operate separately, to a more integrated omnichannel approach that emphasizes consistency across all retail channels (Geng and Ning, 2025). The integration of retail channels aims to deliver a superior customer experience across all touchpoints, commonly referred to as a seamless experience (SE). Customers increasingly use both physical and digital channels across different stages of their shopping journey and expect consistency throughout (Liu *et al.*, 2024). A core objective of omnichannel retailing is to ensure a smooth and consistent experience across these touchpoints (Sharma and Dutta, 2025). SE not only encourages continued omnichannel engagement but also fosters long-term customer loyalty (Chang and Li, 2022). SE is primarily defined by the interconnectivity of touchpoints and smooth customer transitions between them (Chang and Li, 2022). In contrast, inconsistent experiences often lead customers to switch retailers. Seamless transitions reduce cognitive disruptions and enable continuous engagement with the shopping process (Rodríguez-Torrico *et al.*, 2023; Liu *et al.*, 2024), facilitating a state of flow characterized by greater focus, satisfaction, and interaction efficiency.

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Based on this understanding, the study proposes:

H1. Seamless experience is positively related to the flow experience in an omnichannel retail environment.

3.2 Flow experience and shopping intention

Flow experience (FE) refers to an optimal state in which individuals are deeply absorbed in an activity, often losing awareness of time and surroundings (Soren and Chakraborty, 2024). According to Csikszentmihalyi (2000), this state is associated with greater happiness, concentration, and satisfaction. In the shopping context, FE is considered essential, as highly engaged customers tend to immerse themselves in the process (Silva *et al.*, 2023). FE has been widely examined in marketing and is increasingly relevant in omnichannel retailing, where seamless navigation across touchpoints can foster such immersion. Omnichannel integration supports the development of flow state (Liu *et al.*, 2024), which is characterized by focused attention, enjoyment, and emotional involvement (Zhong and Hamouda, 2024). This state enhances positive emotions and can strengthen purchase intentions (Zhang *et al.*, 2025).

Based on this understanding, the study proposes:

H2. Flow experience is positively related to shopping intention in an omnichannel retail environment.

3.3 Experiential value: a mediator between seamless experience and flow experience

The creation and delivery of superior value have long been central to marketing (Koul and Jasrotia, 2025), with research emphasizing that customers increasingly seek value in experiences (Varshneya and Das, 2017). Value extends beyond functional benefits to include experiential and hedonic aspects (Koul and Jasrotia, 2025). As a result, competing solely on product innovation and price is no longer sufficient, with experience emerging as a key source of differentiation (Alexander and Varley, 2025; Sharma *et al.*, 2026). This shift is driven by factors such as demand for personalization, technological advancements, greater awareness, increased choices, and higher purchasing power. In omnichannel retailing, experiential value across touchpoints remains central to the customer journey (Ameen *et al.*, 2021). Accordingly, this study proposes that experiential value acts as a key mediator between seamless experience and flow experience.

Based on this understanding, the study proposes:

H3. Experiential value mediates the relationship between seamless experience and flow experience in an omnichannel retail environment.

4. Research methodology

4.1 Sampling procedure

This study employed purposive sampling to collect data from omnichannel customers in India purchasing beauty and personal care products across multiple channels. The sample included respondents from diverse age and income groups. The minimum sample size was determined using Soper (2026), and out of 450 individuals approached, 351 complete responses were obtained and used for analysis. A screening mechanism ensured the inclusion of only omnichannel customers. Respondents were required to confirm purchases through at least two different channels (e.g. offline stores, e-commerce platforms, brand websites, social media, or mobile apps) within the past three months. Only eligible respondents proceeded, ensuring the final sample reflected a recent omnichannel shopping experience.

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4.2 Data collection procedure

This study used an online questionnaire via Google Forms, with items adapted from validated scales and measured on a five-point Likert scale. Content validity was ensured through evaluation by three academic experts, leading to improvements in clarity and readability. A pilot test with 50 omnichannel customers assessed reliability and validity, with all factor loadings exceeding the recommended threshold of 0.7 (Hair *et al.*, 2011).

This study targeted individuals in India with an omnichannel shopping experience in the beauty and personal care category. Eligibility was validated through items capturing the recency, frequency, and diversity of channel usage. The questionnaire included demographic questions, screening items, and measures of omnichannel shopping behaviour. The sample comprised 351 respondents with a near-equal gender split (49% male, 51% female). Most respondents were aged 18–25 (59.4%), followed by 26–32 (19.6%), 33–39 (14.8%), and 40+ (6.2%). A majority (59.8%) reported annual income below 5 lakhs, with the remaining distributed across higher income brackets. In terms of recent purchases, 15.3% had purchased within a week, 23.9% within 15 days, 25.9% within a month, and 34.7% over a month ago. Informed consent of the respondents was obtained, and confidentiality and anonymity were assured.

4.3 Measurement

This study measured the key constructs using established scales from prior research, with minor adaptations to fit the context of omnichannel beauty and personal care shopping. Seamless experience items were adapted from Chang and Li (2022), experiential value items from Varshneya and Das (2017), flow experience items from Liu *et al.* (2024), and Shopping Intention items from Bian and Forsythe (2012). Table 1 presents the list of the scale items.

5. Data analysis and results

To examine the proposed model and hypotheses, the data were analysed using SmartPLS 4, following the PLS-SEM approach. This method was found suitable because it allows the evaluation of both formative and reflective constructs and is widely used in predictive research (Hair *et al.*, 2019).

5.1 Measurement model

5.1.1 Reliability and validity. The analysis followed the two-step approach. First, the measurement model was evaluated for reliability and validity. Internal consistency was established using Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability (CR), with all values exceeding 0.70 (Hair *et al.*, 2019) (see Table 1). Convergent validity was confirmed as all AVE values were above 0.50 (see Table 1). Discriminant validity was assessed using HTMT. The square root of AVE for each construct exceeded its correlations with others, and all HTMT values were below 0.9, confirming adequate discriminant validity (Hair *et al.*, 2019; Ringle *et al.*, 2023) (see Table 2).

The second-order reflective construct, FE (α = 0.828, CR = 0.831, AVE = 0.593), demonstrated strong internal consistency, with all values exceeding recommended thresholds. For the formative constructs SE and EV, both outer weights and outer loadings were assessed. Most outer weights were statistically significant, indicating the relative contribution of indicators, while all outer loadings were significant, confirming their absolute relevance in forming the higher-order constructs. These results support the reliability and validity of the second-order constructs, justifying the inclusion of all indicators based on both statistical evidence and theoretical support.

5.1.2 Multicollinearity and Common Method Bias (CMB). To ensure content validity, the survey instrument was first reviewed by three academic experts, and then pilot tested with 50 omnichannel customers. The pilot study confirmed the reliability of the constructs, as all

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Table 1. Scale items and factor loadings

	Constructs/Scales	Factor loading
Availability of links (CR = 0.919, α = 0.868, AVE = 0.792)		
SE1	The transition link between various online platforms is smooth	0.917
SE2	The transition link between various online platforms is easy to use	0.903
SE3	The transition link between various online platforms is accessible and loads quickly	0.847
Consistency of sales strategies (CR = 0.871, α = 0.779, AVE = 0.694)		
SE4	The product prices offered by the retailer are consistent	0.776
SE5	The product promotion activities offered by the retailer are consistent	0.894
SE6	The product categories offered by the retailer are consistent	0.825
Information Visibility (CR = 0.876, α = 0.787, AVE = 0.701)		
SE7	I can online check product inventory status of physical store	0.827
SE8	I can keep online track of my transaction records after making a transaction	0.833
SE9	I can online view any new product launch at retailer's physical store	0.853
Simplicity of payment (CR = 0.913, α = 0.857, AVE = 0.777)		
SE10	The retailer provides quick payment method across different platforms	0.901
SE11	The retailer provides convenient payment procedures across different platforms	0.893
SE12	The retailer provides easy payment operations across different platforms	0.849
Flexibility of fulfilment (CR = 0.84, α = 0.718, AVE = 0.637)		
SE13	The retailer supports buy online and pick up in store service option	0.845
SE14	The retailer supports buy offline and delivery to home service option	0.771
SE15	The retailer supports buy online and return/exchange offline service option	0.776
Convenience of sharing (CR = 0.907, α = 0.846, AVE = 0.765)		
SE16	I can share the products and related information I saw in the retailer's physical store with others on social platforms conveniently	0.874
SE17	In physical stores, I can share the products and related information with others on social platforms through mobile immediately	0.865
SE18	I can easily search the product links in the retailer's online store and communicate with others via its social media sharing function	0.884
Perceived Curiosity (CR = 0.928, α = 0.884, AVE = 0.812)		
FE1	Excites my curiosity	0.909
FE2	Makes me curious	0.904
FE3	Arouses my imagination	0.891
Perceived control (CR = 0.904, α = 0.841, AVE = 0.759)		
FE4	I feel in control over my interaction with the retailer	0.879
FE5	I feel that I have control over my interaction with the retailer	0.877
FE6	The retailer allows me to control my interaction with the retailer across different platforms	0.857
Heightened enjoyment (CR = 0.923, α = 0.889, AVE = 0.75)		
FE7	I have fun interacting with the retailer	0.877
FE8	It provides me with a lot of enjoyment	0.859
FE9	I enjoy using retailers' different platforms	0.871
FE10	It makes me happy	0.859
Focussed Immersion (CR = 0.906, α = 0.862, AVE = 0.707)		
FE11	My attention does not get diverted very easily	0.826
FE12	I am able to block out most other distractions	0.83
FE13	I am absorbed in what I am doing	0.859
FE14	I am immersed in the task I am performing	0.848
Temporal Dissociation (CR = 0.925, α = 0.892, AVE = 0.755)		
FE15	Time appears to go by very quickly	0.855

(*continued*)

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Table 1. Continued

	Constructs/Scales	Factor loading
FE16	Sometimes I lose track of time	0.886
FE17	Time flies	0.867
FE18	In most times, I end up spending more time than I had planned	0.869
Cognitive value (CR = 0.932, α = 0.903, AVE = 0.774)		
EV1	Staff members/support across various platforms of the retailer are competent and accessible	0.876
EV2	The services provided by the retailer across various platforms are of acceptable standard	0.883
EV3	The time and effort spent across different platforms of the retailer are worth the experience	0.894
EV4	Overall, the buying process across different platforms is smooth and therefore saves my time	0.865
Hedonic Value (CR = 0.913, α = 0.874, AVE = 0.725)		
EV5	The retailer provides an entertaining shopping experience across multiple platforms	0.848
EV6	Overall, a visit to the retailer, both online and offline, is enjoyable	0.877
EV7	I get so involved when I interact with the retailer that I forget everything	0.825
EV8	Visit to the retailer, either online or offline, serves as a way of temporary escape from daily routine	0.856
Social Value (CR = 0.93, α = 0.9, AVE = 0.77)		
EV9	Shopping helps me in making a good impression on others	0.894
EV10	Shopping provides me social approval	0.882
EV11	My experience with the retailer is important for my esteem, status, and social relationships	0.857
EV12	People and the environment associated with the retailer match with my social status	0.876
Ethical Value (CR = 0.941, α = 0.916, AVE = 0.798)		
EV13	Services provided by the retailer are trustworthy	0.884
EV14	The retailer takes care of my overall security	0.909
EV15	The retailer offers secure payment methods across different platforms	0.894
EV16	The retailer takes care of my privacy	0.887
Shopping intention (CR = 0.902, α = 0.865, AVE = 0.649)		
SI1	I would like to purchase this retailer's product immediately	0.835
SI2	I would like to purchase this retailer's product in the near future	0.79
SI3	I would like to own this retailer's product	0.823
SI4	I'm confident of purchasing this retailer's product regardless of time	0.795
SI5	I would like to introduce this retailer's product to my friends	0.784

Source(s): Authors' own work

values exceeded the 0.70 benchmark. The VIF scores for all indicators ranged from 1.39 to 3.2, which were well within acceptable limits. These values suggested that multicollinearity was not an issue. Also, since all VIF values were below the 3.3 threshold, common method bias was unlikely to affect the results (Hair *et al.*, 2019).

5.1.3 Hierarchical component model assessment. The hierarchical component model was examined to assess the contribution of individual dimensions to the higher-order constructs of seamless experience, experiential value, and flow experience. For seamless experience (SE), the results indicate that availability of links ($\beta = 0.313$) and convenience of sharing ($\beta = 0.306$) contribute most strongly to the construct, highlighting the importance of smooth transitions across channels and the ability to share information or experiences across digital platforms. Simplicity of payment ($\beta = 0.272$) and consistency in sales strategies ($\beta = 0.225$) demonstrate moderate contributions, suggesting that streamlined payment processes and

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Table 2. Discriminant validity – Heterotrait-monotrait ratio (HTMT)

	AOL	COS	CSS	CV	EV1	FI	FOF	HE	HV	IV	PC1	PC2	PS	SV	TD
AOL															
COS	0.551														
CSS	0.515	0.451													
CV	0.562	0.592	0.424												
EV1	0.575	0.557	0.39	0.8											
FI	0.41	0.435	0.423	0.561	0.566										
FOF	0.252	0.403	0.466	0.233	0.215	0.37									
HE	0.509	0.479	0.328	0.704	0.64	0.6	0.267								
HV	0.487	0.55	0.377	0.797	0.745	0.518	0.214	0.629							
IV	0.267	0.374	0.443	0.245	0.222	0.255	0.435	0.191	0.247						
PC1	0.523	0.478	0.349	0.538	0.566	0.511	0.306	0.688	0.543	0.201					
PC2	0.412	0.482	0.366	0.54	0.498	0.551	0.287	0.604	0.508	0.345	0.548				
PS	0.602	0.6	0.443	0.455	0.45	0.375	0.371	0.429	0.32	0.293	0.393	0.378			
SV	0.27	0.216	0.275	0.496	0.609	0.337	0.199	0.342	0.688	0.242	0.369	0.257	0.049		
TD	0.428	0.38	0.293	0.457	0.433	0.551	0.121	0.492	0.503	0.179	0.581	0.471	0.357	0.3	

Note(s): *AOL* – Availability of Links; *CSS* – Consistency of Sales Strategies; *IV* – Information Visibility; *SP* – Simplicity of Payment; *FOF* – Flexibility of Fulfilment; *COS* – Convenience of Sharing; *PC* – Perceived Curiosity; *PC1* – Perceived Control; *HE* – Heightened Enjoyment; *FI* – Focused Immersion; *TD* – Temporal Dissociation; *CV* – Cognitive Value; *HV* – Hedonic Value; *SV* – Social Value; *EV 1* – Ethical Value

Source(s): Authors' own work

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aligned promotional strategies also support perceptions of seamlessness. In contrast, information visibility ($\beta = 0.162$) and flexibility of fulfilment ($\beta = 0.149$) exhibit relatively lower contributions, indicating a comparatively smaller role in shaping the perception of a seamless omnichannel experience.

For experiential value (EV), ethical value ($\beta = 0.327$), and cognitive value ($\beta = 0.317$) emerge as the strongest contributors, suggesting that trust, privacy protection, and service efficiency are central to consumers' value perceptions in the omnichannel context. Hedonic value ($\beta = 0.292$) also contributes, reflecting the importance of enjoyment in the shopping journey, while social value ($\beta = 0.237$) shows a relatively weaker contribution. Regarding flow experience (FE), all dimensions demonstrate strong contributions, with heightened enjoyment ($\beta = 0.824$) contributing most significantly, followed by perceived curiosity ($\beta = 0.787$) and focused immersion ($\beta = 0.767$). Temporal dissociation ($\beta = 0.746$) and perceived control ($\beta = 0.720$) also load strongly, indicating that flow in the shopping context is characterized by enjoyment, deep concentration, and an altered perception of time.

5.2 Structural model

The structural model was assessed by estimating the path coefficients and testing their significance using bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples. The results indicate that SE has a positive and significant effect on FE ($\beta = 0.261$, $p = 0.005$), supporting H1. FE, in turn, exerts a strong positive influence on shopping intention ($\beta = 0.713$, $p < 0.001$), thereby supporting H2 (see Table 3). The model explains a considerable proportion of variance in the endogenous constructs, with R^2 values of 0.539 for FE and 0.507 for shopping intention. To assess model fit, two commonly used indices in PLS-SEM were examined. The SRMR value was 0.069, which is below the recommended threshold of 0.8 (Henseler *et al.*, 2016), indicating a relatively good model fit. The NFI value was 0.882; although the NFI value fell marginally below the conventional cut-off of 0.90, it was deemed acceptable given the predictive nature of PLS-SEM and the satisfactory SRMR value (Hair *et al.*, 2019).

5.3 Mediating test

This study employed a bootstrapping procedure with 5,000 resamples to examine the mediating role of experiential value between seamless experience and flow experience (Hair *et al.*, 2019). Mediation occurs when a predictor variable influences a dependent variable

Table 3. Path coefficient and mediation analysis

Structural model results and model fit indices				
Structural paths	β (Standardized path coefficient)	*t*-value	*p*-value	Result
SE → EV	0.658	14.547	<0.001	Supported
SE → FE	0.261	2.826	0.005	Supported
EV → FE	0.538	6.883	<0.001	Supported
FE → SI	0.713	22.53	<0.001	Supported

Mediation analysis				
Indirect path	β	*t*-value	*p*-value	Result
SE → EV → FE	0.354	7.884	<0.001	Supported
SE → FE → SI	0.186	2.785	0.005	Supported
SE → EV → FE → SI	0.252	6.921	<0.001	Supported

Note(s): *SE* – Seamless Experience; *EV* – Experiential Value; *FE* – Flow Experience; *SI* – Shopping Intention
Source(s): Authors' own work

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indirectly through a mediating construct, thereby explaining the underlying mechanism linking the variables (Hair *et al.*, 2021).

The results indicate that seamless experience (SE) exerts a significant total effect on flow experience (FE) (total effect = 0.615, $p < 0.001$), suggesting a strong overall relationship between the constructs. The indirect effect of SE on FE through experiential value (EV) is also positive and significant (SE → EV → FE: $\beta = 0.354$, $p < 0.001$), confirming the mediating role of EV. Furthermore, the direct effect of SE on FE remains significant ($\beta = 0.261$, $p = 0.005$), indicating that EV partially mediates the relationship between SE and FE. The Variance Accounted For (VAF) was calculated by dividing the indirect effect (0.354) by the total effect (0.615), resulting in a VAF of approximately 57.6%, which falls within the range of partial mediation as suggested by Hair *et al.* (2019). These findings suggest that EV acts as a mediator in facilitating FE, indicating that when customers derive greater EV in the omnichannel shopping process, they are more likely to experience a state of flow during the shopping interaction. Thus, the results provide empirical support for H3, confirming that EV mediates the relationship between SE and FE (see Table 3).

In addition to the hypothesized mediation, FE is also a mediator linking SE and shopping intention. The results reveal a significant indirect effect of SE on shopping intention through FE (SE → FE → SI: $\beta = 0.186$, $p = 0.005$), indicating that seamless interactions within an omnichannel environment foster a state of flow, which in turn strengthens customers' shopping intention. Moreover, a significant serial indirect effect was observed (SE → EV → FE → SI: $\beta = 0.252$, $p < 0.001$), indicating that EV and FE jointly act as key psychological mechanisms through which seamless omnichannel interactions translate into stronger shopping intention (see Table 3).

6. Discussion

This study examines how seamless experience (SE) in an omnichannel beauty and personal care retail translates into flow experience (FE) and shopping intention (SI), while highlighting the mediating role of experiential value (EV). The findings indicate that although seamless integration across channels provides an essential structural foundation for omnichannel retailing, the EV derived during the shopping journey plays a critical role in strengthening the FE.

The results confirm that a SE positively influences FE in the beauty and personal care context. Customers frequently swap between various touchpoints during their omnichannel shopping journey. When these transitions occur smoothly across channels, customers are able to maintain continuity throughout the shopping journey. Such integrated interactions reduce disruption in the shopping process and enable customers to remain focused, thereby facilitating the emergence of an FE.

The findings highlight the central role of EV in strengthening the relationship between SE and FE. Mediation analysis shows that EV partially mediates this relationship, indicating that the value derived from omnichannel interactions enhances customer immersion. Among its dimensions, ethical and cognitive values contribute most strongly in the omnichannel beauty retail context. Ethical value, reflected in trust, transparency, and reliable information, is particularly important when evaluating beauty products online. The strong role of cognitive value suggests that customers prioritize efficiency, ease of navigation, and consistent service delivery across touchpoints. Hedonic value also contributes, indicating that enjoyment and exploration remain integral to the shopping experience, while social value plays a relatively smaller role, suggesting that customer evaluations are driven more by informational and trust-related factors than social interactions.

The findings also emphasize the role of FE as a key psychological state influencing shopping intention in beauty and personal care retailing. Customers who experience a state of flow during the shopping journey are more likely to develop stronger purchase intentions. Flow reflects a condition of deep concentration and intrinsic enjoyment in which customers

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become fully immersed in the shopping activity. Within the beauty and personal care context, this immersion may occur when customers actively explore products, compare alternatives, and engage with informative or visually rich content across channels. Such immersive engagement increases their involvement in the shopping process and strengthens their intention to complete the purchase.

Additionally, the mediating role of FE in the relationship between SE and shopping intention indicates that smooth and integrated interactions across channels enhance shopping intention by enabling consumers to experience a state of flow during their shopping journey. Moreover, the presence of a significant serial mediation effect indicates that EV and FE jointly explain how omnichannel interactions translate into shopping intention. Thus, these findings suggest that omnichannel beauty and personal care shopping experiences unfold through a sequential experiential process. SE establishes the structural continuity of interactions across channels, EV reflects the value customers derive during the shopping journey, and FE captures the immersive psychological state that emerges during the interaction.

7. Implications

7.1 Theoretical implications

Drawing on *Flow Theory* and *Experiential Value Theory*, this study makes multifold contributions to the existing literature by confirming and extending these theoretical perspectives within the context of omnichannel retailing. First, this study contributes to omnichannel retailing literature and *Flow Theory* by linking the psychological construct of flow experience (FE) with the strategic concept of seamless experience (SE). The study contributes to *Flow Theory* by demonstrating that seamless experience serves as an important antecedent of flow experience in omnichannel retailing. *Flow Theory* has traditionally been applied to digital environments where individuals become deeply immersed in an activity through focused attention, enjoyment, and intrinsic motivation (Liu *et al.*, 2024; Zhong and Hamouda, 2024). Meanwhile, seamlessness has primarily been examined from a technological or operational perspective in the existing literature (Chang and Li, 2022). However, this study introduces a psychological lens, positioning seamlessness as a precursor to an immersive flow state. This shift encourages scholars to examine omnichannel integration not only in terms of efficiency but also in terms of its capacity to foster a deeper emotional and cognitive engagement. By demonstrating that FE strongly influences shopping intention and mediates the relationship between SE and shopping intention, the study highlights the relevance of immersive experiences in explaining customer shopping intention within omnichannel retail contexts. Thus, the study broadens the application of *Flow Theory* by identifying seamless experience as a strategic driver of consumers' immersive shopping experiences.

Second, the research contributes to *Experiential Value Theory* by empirically validating its role as a mediator in the omnichannel context. The findings confirm that experiential value is developed cumulatively as consumers interact across multiple online and offline touchpoints rather than through isolated retail encounters (Alexander and Varley, 2025; Xu *et al.*, 2025). Consistent with this perspective, the present research advocates that deriving an EV is an ongoing process throughout the customer interaction with various online and offline touchpoints. It emphasizes that EV goes beyond being a simple result of interface design or service features; instead, it actively encompasses the cognitive, hedonic, social, and ethical dimensions (Varshneya and Das, 2017) that shape consumers' experience throughout their omnichannel journey. This is particularly relevant in omnichannel retailing, where customers continuously move across channels to search for information, evaluate alternatives, and interact with retailers. Thus, the study broadens the application of *Experiential Value Theory* by demonstrating how experiential value operates within integrated omnichannel shopping journeys and subsequently influences customers' shopping intentions.

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Third, the study also highlights the relative importance of the different EV dimensions. The results reveal that ethical value and cognitive value contribute most strongly to EV, suggesting that trust, transparency, access to reliable information, as well as service efficiency, ease of navigation, time savings, and minimal customer effort play a critical role in shaping the omnichannel shopping experience. Thus, by emphasizing the importance of SE, EV, and FE, this study contributes to a deeper understanding of the omnichannel shopping journey of a customer. It challenges the linear, channel-centric shopping journey and supports a more fluid and experience-driven journey where the customer derives several values across touchpoints.

7.2 Practical implications

The findings highlight the importance of designing flow-inducing journeys across each channel. In the beauty and personal care sector, customers often initiate their shopping journey on one channel and complete their purchase on another, making channel swapping a prevalent behaviour. Due to channel swapping, revenue across individual channels becomes inconsistent, despite consistent retailer investments and efforts across channels, making the returns disproportionate. The current research suggests that retailers maintain a consistent experiential value across all channels to induce customers into a flow leading to purchase decisions. Moreover, based on the research findings that cognitive and ethical value contribute more strongly to experiential value in the beauty and personal care sector, we suggest retailers should focus on enhancing transparency and providing reliable product information across channels. By reducing uncertainty and enabling informed decision-making, such efforts may create a more seamless and engaging shopping experience, which can help sustain customers' flow state and, in turn, encourage purchase decisions.

While seamless transitions are important, it is the continuity and consistency of value delivery that sustains the customer's state of flow on the channel. The current research suggests that retailers should aim to eliminate channel fragmentation in the customer experience and ensure that each touchpoint builds on the previous one in a coherent and emotionally resonant manner. This can be done by developing a unified customer ecosystem across channels by leveraging AI-driven personalization, such as skin analysis tools and tailored product recommendations. This will ensure continuity across the touchpoints. This study argues that it is no longer enough for retailers to focus solely on integrating platforms or ensuring a smooth journey across channels. What really matters is how the experience feels to the customer at each step. Seamlessness sets the foundation, but it is the experiential value layered on top, such as how engaging, enjoyable, meaningful, and trustworthy the journey is, that creates real impact. The implications of the current study extend beyond the beauty and personal care sector, offering scope for further exploration in sectors such as fashion, luxury retail, and others.

7.3 Societal implications

This research has contributed towards highlighting some societal contributions by including the role of omnichannel retail environments on the psychological states and decision-making of consumers. The results strongly highlighted that ethical and cognitive value are the most significant contributors to experiential value for consumers in the beauty and personal care sectors. So, providing consumers with transparency and credible information is of importance to their experience. Consumers are confronted daily with misleading claims and information overload in both the digital and physical world, and therefore, by focussing on ethical value in the design of retail spaces, marketers are allowing consumers to make more informed and autonomous purchasing decisions. Additionally, it is important to note that creating a seamless and immersive shopping journey is not only a marketing tool, but it also provides the opportunity for consumers to interact with and process information across multiple experience points or "touchpoints." Creating flow within meaningful, credible and interactive experiences aligns with the goals of responsible consumption and the innovation of retail. As omnichannel

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retailing continues to gain ground across many different segments of consumers, ensuring these environments are built on a foundation of trust and clarity of information will ultimately result in greater social responsibility and consumer awareness within the retail industry.

8. Limitations and future research directions

This study has certain limitations that provide opportunities for future research. First, the findings are based on omnichannel customers in the beauty and personal care sector in India, which may limit the generalizability of the results across other retail contexts. Future studies may explore the proposed model in other sectors such as fashion, luxury, and grocery retailing. Second, the present study employed a survey-based approach; future research could adopt other methods, like experimental designs and longitudinal studies, to gain deeper insights into customer shopping intentions in omnichannel retail contexts. Finally, while this study examined the mediating role of experiential value, future studies may explore additional mediators and moderators to further enrich the understanding of customer behaviour in omnichannel retail environments.

AI declaration

The manuscript was proofread using AI tools to improve grammar and overall readability.

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